

# Open source has more headroom in India than anywhere else

When companies like NIIT Technologies Ltd adopt open source technologies, they take the technology to the next level with their innovation and development, creating a trend of sorts in this domain. NIIT Technologies works on open source projects, contributes to the community and hires open source professionals for its projects. If given a choice, the company chooses open source technologies over proprietary solutions because it gets adequate talent and is ready to train engineers in relevant technologies, if required. **Diksha P Gupta** from **OSFY** spoke to **Arvind Mehrotra, president, APAC, India & Middle East, NIIT Technologies**, about the scope for open source professionals at NIIT Tech and what the company looks for. Excerpts:



Arvind Mehrotra, president, APAC, India & Middle East, NIIT Technologies

**Q** Do you feel India is rich enough in open source talent and do you get the kind of trained manpower you want for NIIT Tech?

There is cutting-edge work constantly happening in open source. So, today if I were to look at it, yes, there is sufficient talent available. As to whether there is an enthusiastic workforce for open source in particular, is an open question. I think it's a 50:50 kind of ratio. People take IT as a career option, whereas open source requires one to play the role of a continuous evangelist on the technology front. People opting for IT as a career are selecting the industry, are focusing on certain business processes and certain types of applications to further their roles and careers. So, if you talk about the availability of a workforce, yes, it is available but has to be groomed correctly. A lot of those qualified have the aptitude and the attitude to be evangelists for open source. But open source is a culture where people will make mistakes. It requires openness to download applications, work on them and contribute back; whereas, in a formal organisation, we are worried about the legal implications of copying a piece of code and embedding it into work that we are contracted to deliver to our customer. So we have formal barriers there.

We cannot allow that because we will carry those risks. We do not want someone else later claiming ownership of the code our engineers say that they have created. There are legal and contractual implications that prevent businesses from inducting open source applications easily.

**Q** You said people can become open source evangelists if you train them right. Do you train people when they come on board at NIIT Tech?

Yes we do. NIIT Tech has made an open source commitment. Before the cloud was launched, we used to make 'Build My Application' (BMA). It was a framework for rapid application development. We did market it. When we realised that people were finding it difficult to retain the code and maintain it because it was being generated by a RAD equivalent tool, we allowed it to go to the open source community so that others could continue to use it and build their own applications with that. So that has been our contribution, and that momentum and spirit continues to fuel the organisation to make more such contributions.

As far as training the professionals is concerned, we have a schedule calendar and a huge library of training material